

LECTURE 02

**Arrival of British and Beginning of Hindu–Muslim
Tension in India (1857–1914)**

War of Independence, Its Impact & Colonial Legacy

1. Arrival of the British in India (Background)

- The British first came to India in the 17th century through the East India Company. Their main purpose was trade, especially in spices, cotton, and silk. At that time, India was rich and famous for its resources and industries.
 - Slowly, the British became more powerful. They started interfering in local politics and fighting wars with Indian rulers. By the 19th century, they had taken control of most parts of India.
- Instead of only trading, they began to:
- Collect taxes
 - Control the army
 - Make laws
 - Rule over the people
 - This was the beginning of British colonial rule in India.

2. War of Independence (1857)

- In 1857, a major revolt started against British rule. This was the first big attempt by Indians to remove British control. In Pakistan and India, it is called the **War of Independence**, while the British call it the **Mutiny of 1857**.

➤ Major Causes:

- Indian soldiers were treated badly by British officers
- Religious beliefs were hurt (cartridges issue)
- Heavy taxes made farmers poor
- Local rulers lost their kingdoms
- People were tired of foreign rule
- Both Hindus and Muslims took part in this war and fought together against the British.

3. Failure of the War and Its Effects

- The War of Independence failed because:
- There was no proper planning
- There was no strong central leadership
- Modern weapons were not available
- Some local rulers supported the British

➤ After the war:

- The British became more strict and powerful
- The East India Company's rule ended
- The British government directly ruled India from London
- Muslims were blamed more for the revolt
- As a result:
- Many Muslims were killed or punished
- Muslim properties were taken away
- Muslims lost jobs and political power
- This made Muslims socially and economically weak.

4. Beginning of Hindu–Muslim Tension (1857–1914)

- Before 1857, Hindus and Muslims had many differences but they lived together and even fought together against the British.
- After 1857, the British adopted a policy called “**Divide and Rule.**” This means they tried to create hatred and misunderstanding between Hindus and Muslims so they could rule easily.

➤ **How they created tension:**

- They treated Hindus and Muslims differently
- They gave more opportunities to one group at times
- They spread the idea that both communities were different and could not live together
- Political competition increased between them
- Because of this:
 - Trust between Hindus and Muslims slowly decreased
 - Separate political thinking started developing
 - Unity became weaker
- This period (1857–1914) was the beginning of serious Hindu–Muslim differences.

5. British Colonial Rule in India

- Colonial rule means when a powerful country controls another country and uses its resources for its own benefit.

➤ During British rule:

- Indians had no real power in government
- British controlled the army, economy, and administration
- Raw materials were taken from India to Britain
- British goods were sold in India
- This damaged local industries and made many people poor.
- Farmers had to pay heavy taxes, and many small businesses were destroyed.

- **6. The Colonial Legacy (Long-Term Effects)**

- Colonial legacy means the effects of British rule that remained even after they left India.

- **Positive Effects:**

- Railways and roads were built
- Modern education system started
- English language became common
- New legal and administrative systems were introduced

- **Negative Effects:**

- Economic problems and poverty increased
- Local industries were destroyed
- Social and political divisions grew
- Hindu–Muslim tension increased
- These divisions later played a major role in the demand for a separate Muslim state.

7. Overall Impact on Society

- The arrival of the British changed India completely:
- Political system changed
- Economy became weaker
- Education system became modern
- Society became divided
- Most importantly, unity between Hindus and Muslims was affected, which later led to separate political movements.

8. Conclusion

- The arrival of the British marked a major turning point in the history of India. The War of Independence in 1857 was the first strong reaction against foreign rule. After the war, the British became more powerful and started policies that created division between Hindus and Muslims.
- From 1857 to 1914, tensions slowly increased due to political, social, and economic differences. British colonial rule left both positive and negative effects, but its biggest impact was the long-term division in society that later influenced the future of the subcontinent.